ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 2B

Analysing Conversation

University of Glasgow

Conversation 2

Starts, Ends, and Errors

Marc Alexander

Week 5





Repairs



Errors



Closings



Greetings



Pre-Sequences



Side Sequences



Insertion Sequences



Adjacency Pairs



Pauses



Overlaps



Turn-Taking

Pre-Sequences

Pre-sequences are turns or adjacency pairs that lead up to a particular (more important) adjacency pair

- For example, a question-answer pair which occurs before an invitation
  - Leads up to a particular ‘core’ adjacency pair
- Pre-invitation, pre-question, pre-request, and pre-announcements are most common

A Are you doing anything on Friday?

B No, why?

A We’re all going to the pub.

B That sounds nice.

A Would you like to come along?

B That sounds lovely.

PRE-INVITATION (=QUESTION)	A	Are you doing anything on Friday?
ANSWER	B	No, why?
PRE-INVITATION (=STATEMENT)	A	We’re all going to the pub.
ACKNOWLEDGEMENT	B	That sounds nice.
INVITATION	A	Would you like to come along?
ACCEPTANCE	B	That sounds lovely.

A Are you doing anything on Friday?

B No, why?

A We’re all going to the pub.

B That sounds nice.

A Would you like to come along?

B That sounds lovely.

A Are you doing anything on Friday?

B No, why?

A I just wondered. Popular people usually have plans on Fridays.

A Are you doing anything on Friday?

B Yes, I’m off to Paris for the weekend.

A Lucky you!

A Are you doing anything on Friday?

B No, why?

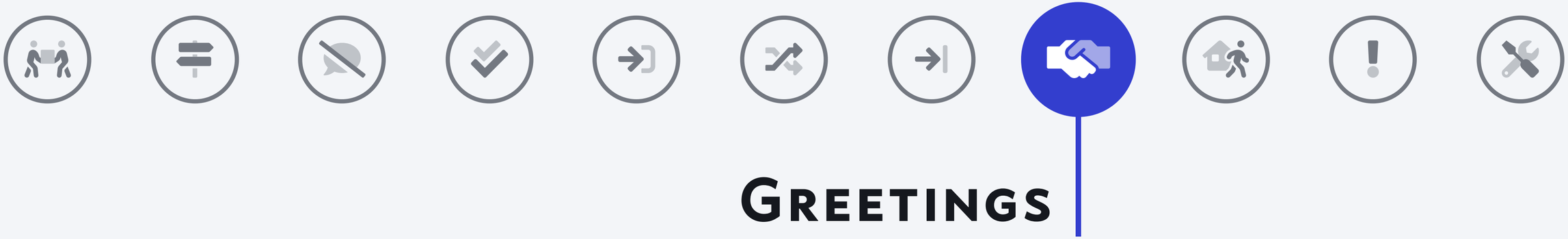
A Oh good, we’re looking for someone to babysit on Friday night.

A Are you doing anything on Friday?

B No, why?

A Oh good, we're looking for someone to babysit on Friday night.

B Ah, I thought you meant Friday *daytime*.



Greetings

What turns are used at the opening of a conversation?

- What turns characterize openings remotely and in person?
- How do these differ in structure and layout?

Greetings

Remotely (eg telephone calls):

- Summons/answer pair
- Identification/recognition pair
- Greetings
- Personal enquiry (question/answer pair)
- Initiation of topic

C *[Causes phone to ring at R's location]*

R Hello?

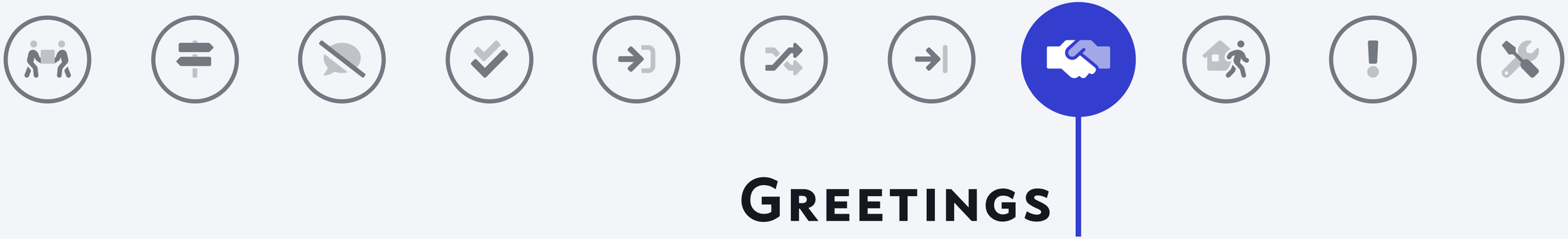
C Hi, it's Fraser!

R Oh, hi Fraser!

C How're things?

R Good, you?

C Yeah, fine, thanks. Listen, I was wondering if…



Greetings

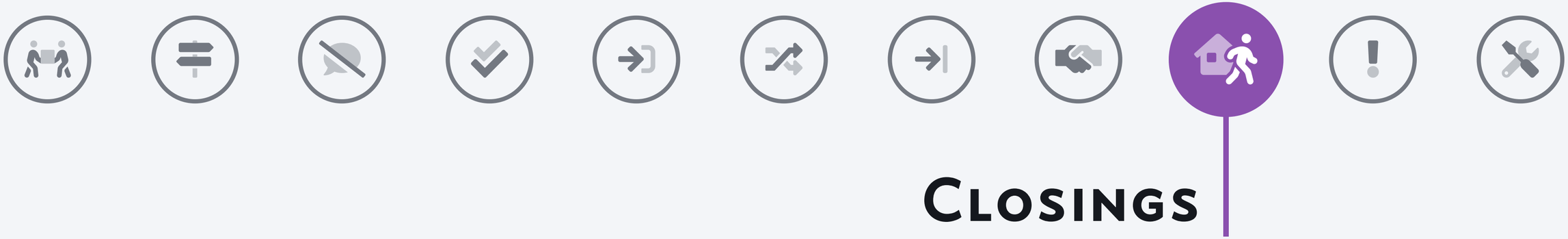
Remotely (eg telephone calls):

- Summons/answer pair
- Identification/recognition pair
- Greetings
- Personal enquiry (question/answer pair)
- Initiation of topic

Greetings

In person, many are similar as remotely, but lots are are optional depending on the context, and also with contextual additions in any structure:

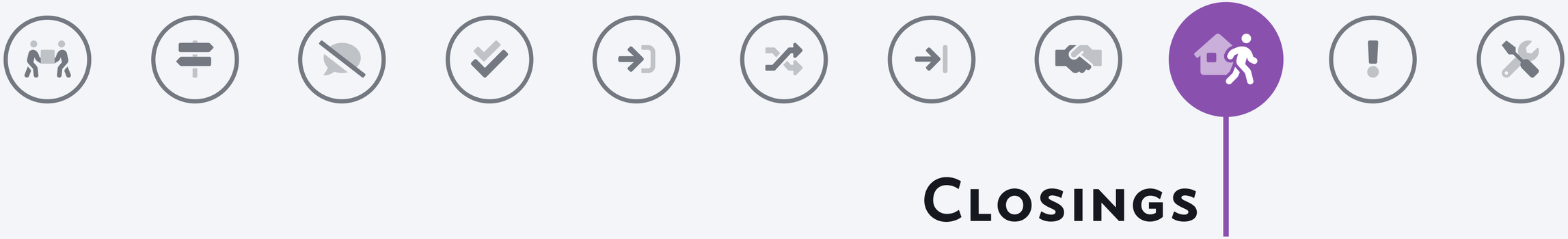
- Self/other-oriented comments
- Neutral contextual comments – e.g. about the weather, journey, etc
- Offers – e.g. drinks



Closings

What turns characterize the close of a conversation?

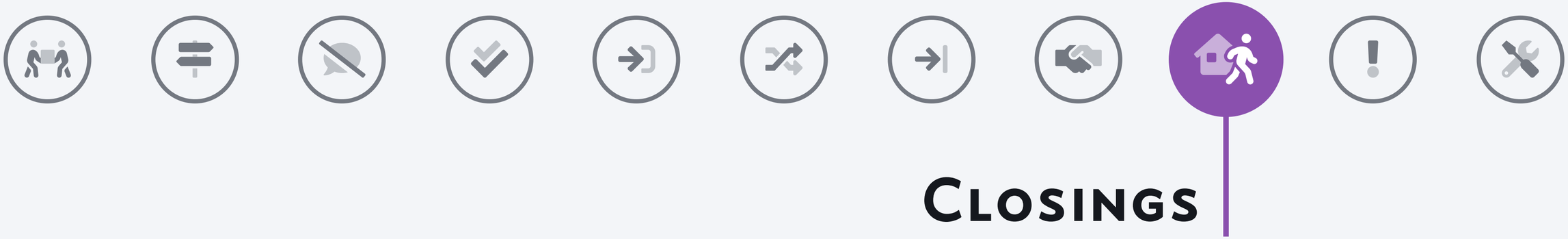
- How do conversations end?
- What moves indicate a conversation is about to end (pre-closings)?
- What affects the speed of a closing?



Closings

A conversation closes with:

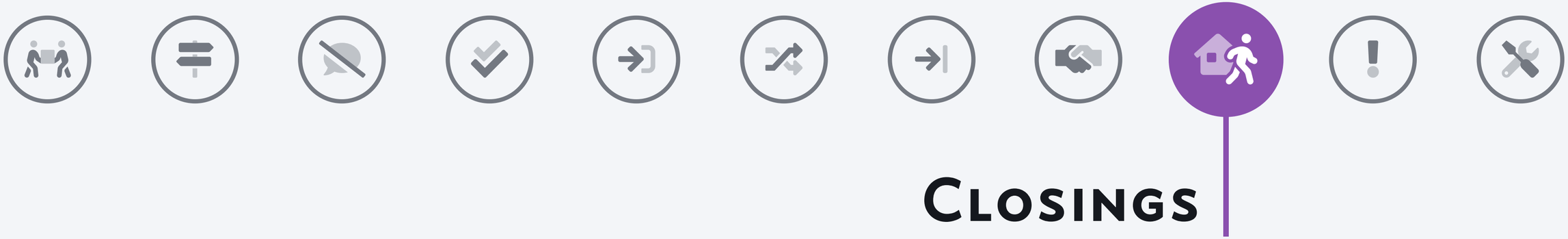
- Closing signals (*Okay, All right, So, Right, Good, Well*)
- Terminal elements (*Bye, then, Bye, See you*)



Closings

Pre-closings are the build-up to a conversation ending (often several moves):

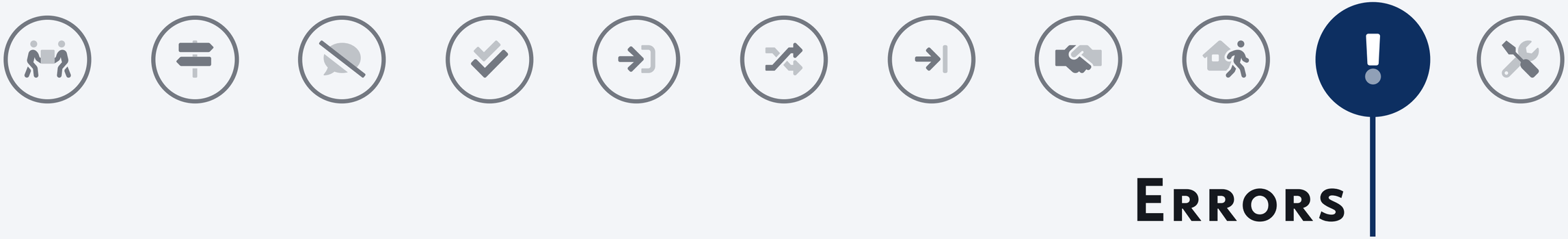
- Future arrangements
- Broad indication of future meeting
- C/R makes excuses
- Onus shifted to C
- Onus shifted to R
- Reason for call
- Solicitudes
- Back references
- Thanking



Closings

Standard closings are four turns, disrupted by:

- Misplacement markers (*Oh, by the way*)
- Foreshortened closing (*Right, okay, bye then*)
- Extended closing (many closing signals, reluctance to start terminal elements)



Errors

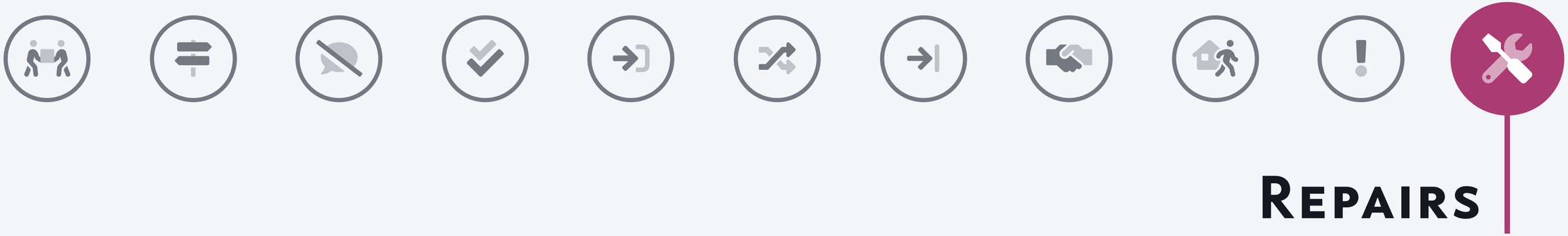
Speakers can make mistakes and hearers can mishear:

Speakers

- Hesitation phenomena (repetition, pauses, fillers, place-finders, changes)
- Speech errors (slips of the tongue, mispronunciation, malapropisms)
- Memory problem
- Interaction errors (overlaps, misplacement markers)
- Wrong information
- Insufficient information/ambiguity

Hearers

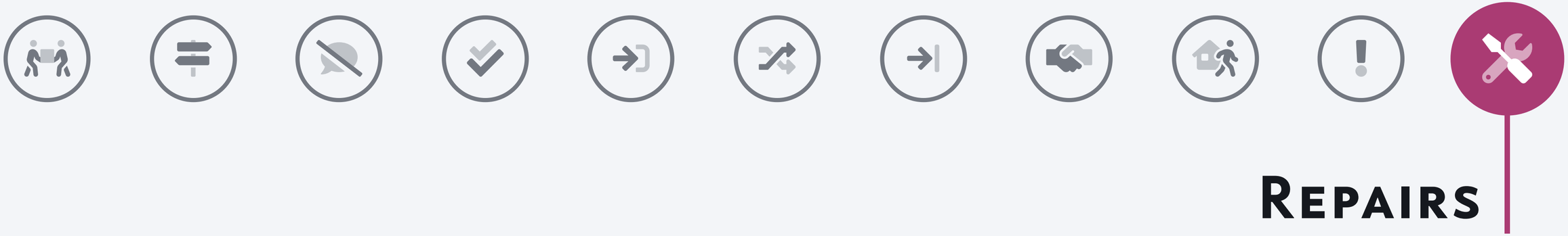
- Speaker is unclear
- Background noise
- Hearer has hearing problem
- Hearer is a child, has medical issues, uncertain grasp of language
- Hearer mistakes the illocution
- Hearer has wrong world-knowledge



Repairs

A repair resolves a communication problem (eg because of an error) by making a correction at a TRP:

- The speaker can notice their own error, or the hearer can
  - *Self-initiated or other-initiated*
- The speaker can correct their own error, or the hearer can
  - *Self-repair or other-repair*
- Obvious politeness preference for self-repair



Repairs

Where can a repair happen:

Opportunity 1

self-initiated self-repair during the same turn as the error

→

Opportunity 2

self initiates repair at TRP and self-repairs

→

Opportunity 3

self initiates repair at TRP and other-repairs

→

Opportunity 4

other initiates repair at TRP and self-repairs

→

Opportunity 5

other initiates repair at TRP and other-repairs

A I saw him arrive on Sunday, and –

wait, no, I mean *Saturday* – and he…

Self-initiated self-repair

A I’ve got to get my, whatchamacallit, prescription sorted…

Self-initiated self-repair

A If we do it that way, people will be able to opt-out of being phoned. I mean *in*.

Self-initiated self-repair at a TRP

A The trackpad on my laptop is making my wrist hurt, I need to go buy a… um, a thingy, you know…

B A mouse?

A Yeah, I need to get a mouse.

Self-initiated other-repair

A Let’s go into town, I’ve got book vouchers for Waterman’s to use.

B For… “Waterman’s”?

A Oh, I mean *Waterstones*.

Other-initiated self-repair

A Let’s go into town, I’ve got book vouchers for Waterman’s to use.

B Do you mean *Waterstones*?

A Oh, yeah.

Other-initiated other-repair

A Let’s go into town, I’ve got book vouchers for Waterman’s to use.

B Waterstones, yeah, let’s go there.

Other-initiated other-repair

A So what do you think about the news?

B What news?

A The whole election thing!

B Oh that, yeah, that's terrible...

Other-initiated self-repair

A Then we went to the capital, Toronto.

B Isn’t Ottawa the capital?

A Oh, yes, of course.

Other-initiated other-repair

A Then we went to the capital, Toronto.

B I *think* Ottawa might be the capital?

A Ah, I think you're right, yes.

Other-initiated other-repair

A Then we went to the capital, Toronto.

B You mean Ottawa, you fuckwit.

A Who even cares, Toronto's the big one with all the stuff.

Other-initiated other-repair

A So I’ll see you Friday.

B No, tomorrow.

A Tomorrow, yeah.

Other-initiated other-repair

A So I’ll see you Friday.

B No, tomorrow.

A Don’t think so, definitely Friday, because tomorrow you said you’re at that thing.

Rejection of a repair



Repairs



Errors



Closings



Greetings



Pre-Sequences



Side Sequences



Insertion Sequences



Adjacency Pairs



Pauses



Overlaps



Turn-Taking